UCLA College Physical Sciences

Department of Mathematics
520 Portola Plaza
Box 951555
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1555

February 2nd, 2026

Letter of recommendation for Nicholas Hu

I am delighted to nominate Nicholas Hu for a Distinguished TA award. Nicholas is an innovative and effective TA, and has also served as a Graduate Student Instructor (GSI) in four classes, two at the undergraduate level and two at the graduate level. In 2024, and with the unanimous support of the Dept. Teaching Committee he was the recipient of the Liggett Teaching Fellow award, which is our department's highest honor for TAs. Most of our TAs specialize in one area of mathematics, but what distinguishes Nicholas, first, is that he has been a TA for a huge variety of classes, from the first classes in a student's freshman experience, to introductory graduate classes designed to prepare our graduate students for our rigorous qualifying exams. He is equally comfortable as a TA in calculus, as he is in numerical analysis and analysis. In particular, he has TAed for important bridge point courses – the transition from high school math to college math, the bridge to proof and upper division mathematics, and the bridge to graduate level courses. These are challenging classes for our students, and Nicholas meets them where they are, with abundant supports married to very high standards. It is easy in all classes, to allow a partial, or even mildly incorrect, answer to stand, since it can take substantial effort to defend a grade to a student, but Nicholas is well known for the rigor of his grading (again married to substantial in and out of class supports), that push students toward mature writing of mathematics. Although students are not always grateful beneficiaries of this rigor, they benefit from it, and many students appreciate the high standard in retrospect.

I want to highlight a couple of Nicholas' teaching innovations, that I have enjoyed watching. In Math 115A during the last academic year, he introduced proof studies through active learning. This is a powerful idea – our students struggle with proof writing, and part of this is the limited cycle of writing a proof, seeing it graded and trying to do better next time. Nicholas widened the loop to include a process of peer review, so that students could grow by critically evaluating the proofs of others, and having their proofs reviewed in term. Of course, to make this work, Nicholas had to successfully create the right classroom climate – of trust and inquiry – but it also strikes me that this is an excellent way to marshal our TA resources toward more effective teaching in a time of growing resource uncertainty. More recently, Math 290, was a class that Nicholas created and ran, along with another outstanding TA, Olha Shevchenko, with the goal of supporting more graduate students to pass our qualifying exams. The class was a set of guided problem-solving activities, that helped students gain content mastery and develop their exam technique. The class was piloted in 2025, but was so successful that we ran it again this year. With Nicholas graduating this summer, these is real urgency in finding someone as qualified as he is to sustain the class (i.e., knowledgeable in multiple areas of mathematics, which is rare even among senate faculty members).

In summary, Nicholas is an effective instructor, who expects much of his students and gives them more. It is hard to imagine a TA better fitted for this award, and he has my highest recommendation.

Yours faithfully,

Marcus Roper

Professor of Mathematics and Computational Medicine

Undergraduate Vice Chair
UCLA Department of Mathematics
7911 Math Sciences Building
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Nominee Statement

Nicholas Hu

I have been a teaching assistant for the past 10 years (5 years each at UBC and UCLA), during which I have had the honour of teaching over 20 different courses, spanning a wide range of mathematics and computer science subjects from the introductory undergraduate to the advanced graduate level. Throughout these years, I have continually identified areas for improvement in student learning and have developed and enacted educational interventions using evidence-based teaching strategies. For my work, I was recognized with the Graduate Teaching Assistant Award at UBC in 2021 and the Liggett Departmental Teaching Assistant Award at UCLA in 2024.

To inform my pedagogical practice, I have actively pursued professional development opportunities beyond mandatory TA training courses, such as the supplementary Mathematics Teaching Techniques course and Instructional Skills Workshop at UBC, as well as the year-long GRAD PD 496 course sequence at UCLA. Concurrently, I have been completing the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning Certificate program. This multi-level program begins with the completion of evidence-based teaching courses and workshops and culminates with the design, implementation, and presentation of an educational research project called a "Teaching-as-Research" (TAR) project.

My TAR project was motivated by my observations of the challenges faced by students transitioning to abstract, writing-intensive, proof-based mathematics, such as not knowing how or when to articulate and justify mathematical arguments. Accordingly, I investigated how making students critique their proof-writing develops their writing abilities and beliefs about communication in mathematics. I implemented this project as the instructor of record in two core undergraduate mathematics courses at UCLA – real analysis (MATH 131A) and linear algebra (MATH 115A) – redesigning these courses to place greater emphasis on critical writing and problem solving. Instead of passively receiving information through lectures, students wrote proofs and solved problems in groups, actively constructing theorems and results, and then presented their findings to their peers. When students devised arguments, instead of unilaterally judging their validity, I invited students to interrogate, debate, and revise their reasoning among themselves. I also procured a specialized classroom with multiple whiteboards and mobile tables, and employed several undergraduate peer tutors (called "learning assistants") to help facilitate these activities. [Artifact 1] To my knowledge, these activities were the first of their kind in these courses, which had historically been taught using instructor-centred and passive learning techniques. My study conclusively showed that by the end of these courses, students had developed a deeper understanding of and appreciation for writing and communication in mathematics. [Artifact 2]

Likewise, as a teaching assistant, I have striven to be simultaneously critical and supportive, "balancing holding [students] to a high standard … and being empathetic, helpful, understanding, and non-judgemental while helping [students] succeed", as one

student put it. This is well attested to by comments in my Student Evaluations of Teaching over the past several years. [Artifact 3]

In addition, last year, I served as one of my department's Teaching Assistant Consultants (TACs), and as such was responsible for co-teaching our department's TA training course with the other TAC and a faculty member. Together, we mentored new TAs and notably observed every TA individually in both a microteaching session before the quarter and a full discussion section during the quarter, providing comprehensive feedback after each observation.

We expanded on our work as TACs in the following quarter by creating and organizing our department's first-ever qualifying exam preparation seminar (MATH 290M) to provide graduate students with a dedicated time and space for individual and group study. By supplying units toward the enrolment requirement, this highly popular seminar also relieved students from having to take several courses while studying for their exams. Our contributions as coordinators included organizing study groups, holding review sessions, administering practice exams, collecting exam resources online on Bruin Learn/Canvas and Piazza, and creating a Discord server for online discussions. [Artifact 4] The success and value of our course is evidenced by our students' strong performance in the exams and the department's decision to offer the seminar again this year, with plans to continue it in perpetuity.

Last but not least, I have sought to cultivate a more equitable teaching and learning community in academia at large. To this end, I have served on several equity-oriented departmental committees at UCLA, such as the Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion and STEMM Equity Achievement Change committees. While on these committees, I have ensured that students – especially students of colour such as myself – are represented and heard, for instance, by liaising with student societies and underrepresented and marginalized students in our department.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

Nicholas Hu

Over the course of my career as a post-secondary educator, the world has changed profoundly, and I have often been faced with the question: what kind of teaching is called for in this day and age? Taking inspiration from the critical pedagogies of Paulo Freire and bell hooks, I have attempted to formulate an answer by developing a personal teaching philosophy and practice based on the principles of *transgression*, *critique*, and *liberation*. As case studies, I present my experiences as instructor-of-record for two core undergraduate mathematics courses at UCLA – real analysis (131A) and linear algebra (115A).

Following hooks, I conceive of *transgression* as a "movement against and beyond boundaries" (hooks, 1994, p. 12), especially those that circumscribe education as "an act of depositing" or "banking" (Freire, 1970, p. 45). Thus, I began by completely redesigning these courses when I taught them. Instead of passively receiving information through lectures, students wrote proofs and solved problems in groups, actively constructing theorems and results, thereby becoming "critical co-investigators in dialogue with the teacher" (Freire, 1970, p. 54). For this purpose, I procured a specialized classroom with multiple whiteboards and mobile tables, and employed several undergraduate peer tutors (called "learning assistants") to help facilitate these activities. In 115A, we used both the "lecture" and "discussion" periods for active and inquiry-based learning, and my teaching assistant and I regularly taught together or in each other's sections, dissolving and defying the demarcation between the two. Students noted in the mid-quarter survey that "the pedagogical approach [was] really interesting" and that "the collaborative atmosphere is also something that [they did] not see a lot of in [their] courses". Others expressed enthusiasm about "using all 5 days of the week to have an interactive discovery of the theorems" and "discovering answers to questions with peers". In addition, I remodelled the established, traditional assessment scheme containing a small number of heavily-weighted summative assessments (e.g., midterms and a final exam) into a diversified scheme incorporating several formative assessments (e.g., participation, lecture scribing, peer reviews, short quizzes). I also substantially revised and reorganized the course content, adding several topics not usually covered and presenting concepts in novel or unconventional ways.

I ground these numerous activities methodologically in *critique* – thoroughgoing analysis that investigates assumptions, claims, justifications, and conclusions. For instance, when students composed proofs in class, instead of unilaterally judging their validity, I invited students to interrogate, debate, and revise their reasoning among themselves. Moreover, I modelled this dialogical process with my teaching assistant, and we encouraged them to be similarly critical of our proofs as instructors. In 131A, students also partook in a written peer review process as part of their homework. They thus became conscious of the communicative nature of mathematics and its discursive construction of knowledge. Reflecting on this at the end of the course, they averred that

"communication is as much to tell everybody else what I am thinking as it is to tell me what I am thinking" and "understandability and validity can very much go hand in hand [and] are both subject to interpretation". Furthermore, I extended the practice of critique to the level of teaching itself by creating channels such as online surveys and discussion fora through which students could speak candidly and critically about their learning environments and experiences. In response to these conversations, I often found myself making significant structural changes to the course, fulfilling hooks' exhortation that "engaged pedagogy recognize each classroom as different, that strategies … constantly be changed, invented, reconceptualized to address each new teaching experience" (hooks, 1994, pp. 10–11).

In his survey of critical pedagogy, Joe Kincheloe (2008) reminds us that "any time teachers develop a pedagogy, they are concurrently constructing a political vision" (pp. 9–10). Indeed, in the process of fostering students' critical faculties through mathematics, I ultimately aim to enable a much greater 'transgression': *liberation*. As Freire (1970) explains, since "the banking approach to adult education … will never propose to students that they critically consider reality" (p. 47), "those truly committed to liberation … must abandon the educational goal of deposit-making and replace it with the posing of the problems of human beings in their relations with the world" (p. 52). To give a few examples of how this might be done, at the beginning of 115A, I explained to my students that settler colonialism continues to structure the relationship of the university and its community to Indigenous peoples, and urged them to consider the roles mathematics plays in processes of settler colonialism and imperialism throughout the world – from the cultural supersession of Indigenous conceptions of quantity and space, to the material production of technologies for dispossession, exploitation, and elimination. We also had thoughtful in-class discussions about current events throughout the quarter, such as a campus worker strike and the annual commemoration of the Nakba, and reflected on their connections to us as practitioners of mathematics and science.

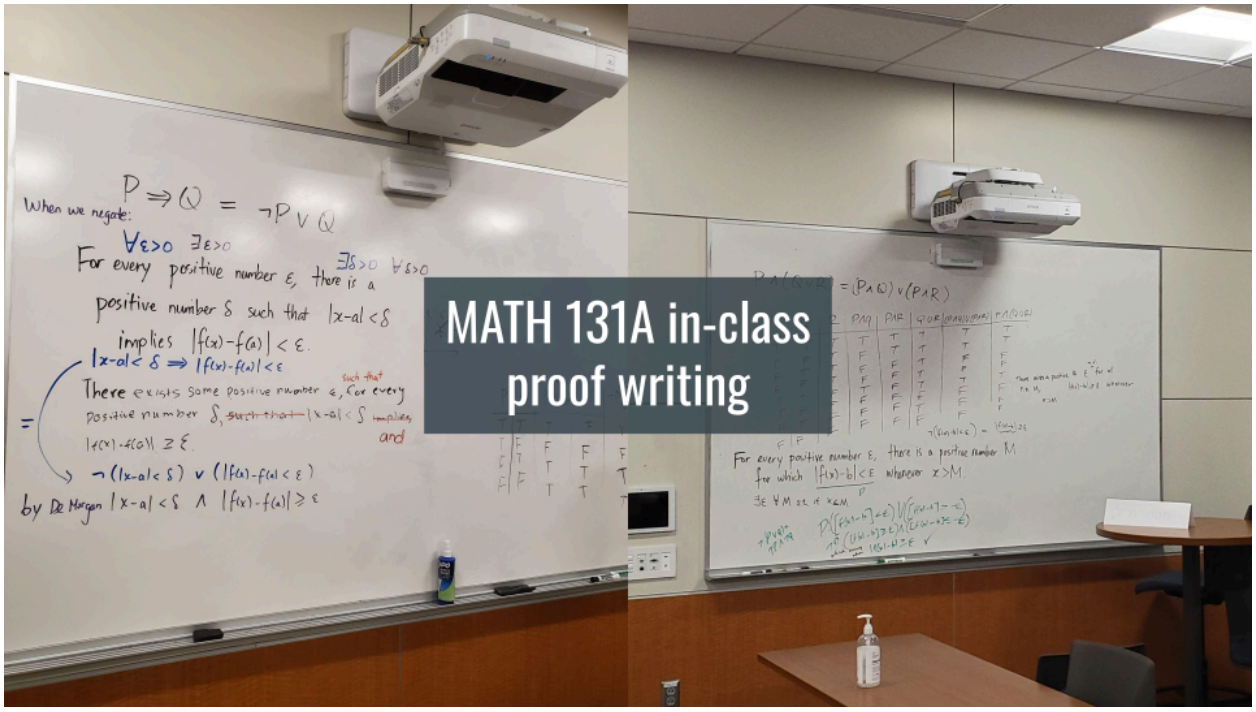
In the same vein, I believe that all educators have a responsibility to cultivate teaching and learning communities beyond the classroom as well. To this end, I have served on my department's Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion Committee and have ensured that marginalized students are represented and heard by liaising with various student societies. I have also co-taught our Teaching Assistant training course as a Teaching Assistant Consultant, mentoring new TAs in the techniques of active learning, assessment and grading, inclusive classrooms, and lesson planning; and I have observed and provided constructive feedback to returning TAs and new instructors as a member of our Teaching Committee.

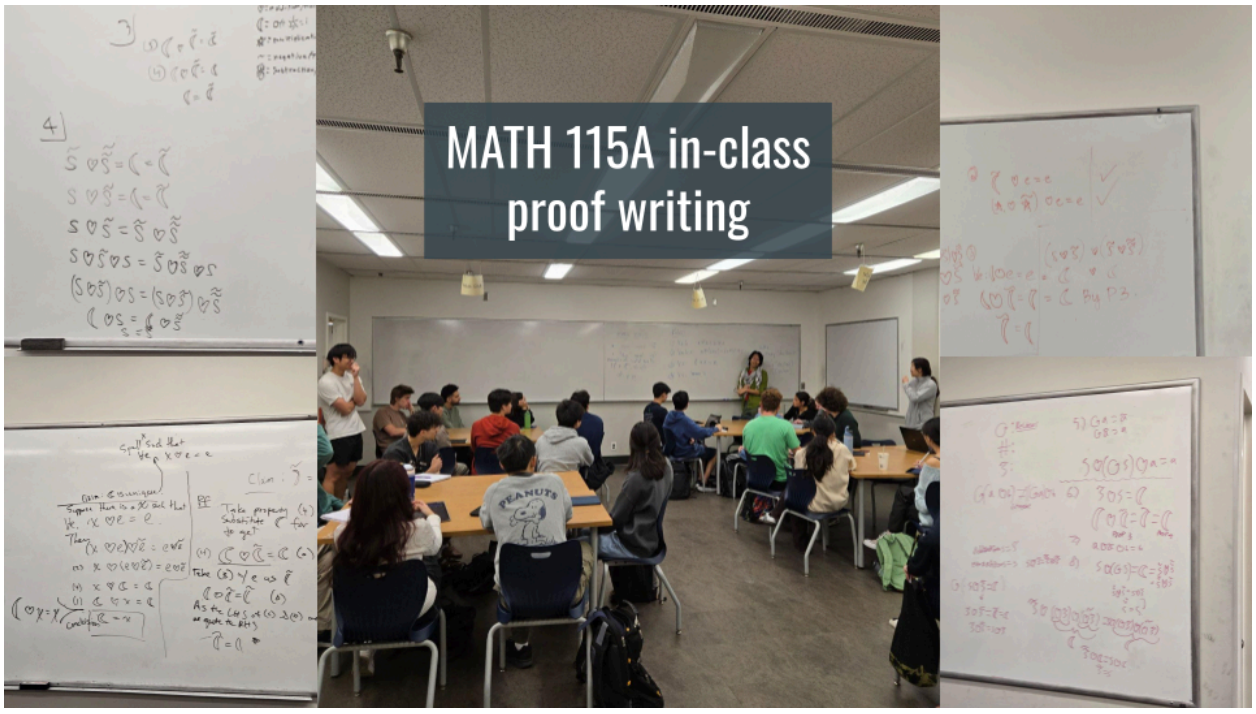
Writing this at UCLA in 2026, at a time when the state of higher education seems more precarious than ever, I aspire to embody hooks' optimism as she writes, "The classroom, with all its limitations, remains a location of possibility … to face reality even as we collectively imagine ways to move beyond boundaries, to transgress. This is education as the practice of freedom." (hooks, 1994, p. 207)

Artifact 1: Teaching-as-Research Project Photographs

Nicholas Hu

Below is an excerpt from a presentation of the results of my Teaching-as-Research (TAR) project. These photographs show mathematical proofs that groups of students wrote during the in-class proof-writing activities.





Artifact 2: Teaching-as-Research Project Results

Nicholas Hu

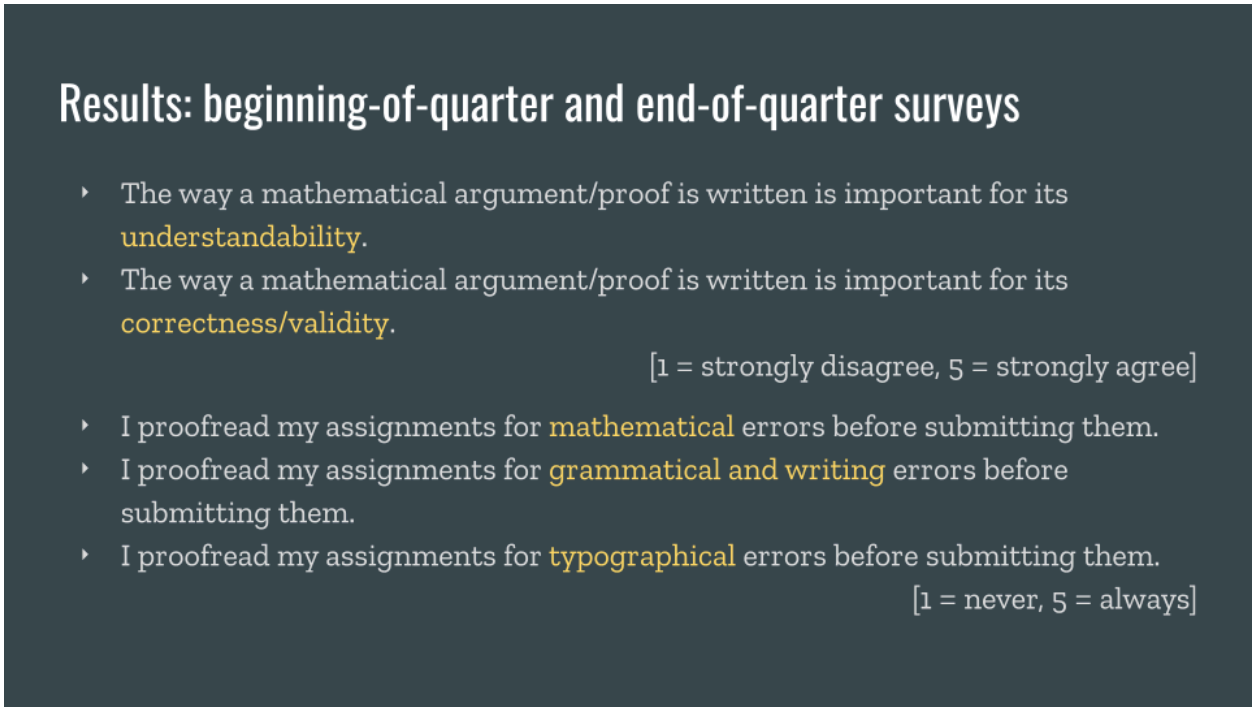
Below is an excerpt from a presentation of the results of my Teaching-as-Research (TAR) project. The learning objectives of this project were:

1. *Students will* assess *the correctness and understandability of their proofs and their peers' proofs by collaboratively writing and discussing proofs in class and/or reviewing their peers' homework assignments.*
2. *Students will* recognize the value of *communication in mathematics by engaging in proof writing activities throughout the course.*

The quantitative data collected included responses to beginning-of-quarter and end-of-quarter Likert scale survey questions. Statistical tests (paired t-tests) showed that at the end of the quarter, MATH 115A students agreed significantly more with the statement "The way a mathematical argument/proof is written is important for its correctness/validity" than at the beginning of the quarter, and that they "proofread [their] assignments for mathematical errors before submitting them" significantly more frequently.

The qualitative data collected included responses to the mid-quarter open-ended survey questions "What is working well for your learning in this class?" and "Has this course changed your view of writing and communication in mathematics? If so, in what ways? If not, why not?"

Overall, we found strong evidence that the project's learning objectives were achieved as a result of the interventions in MATH 115A, and to a lesser extent in MATH 131A as well.

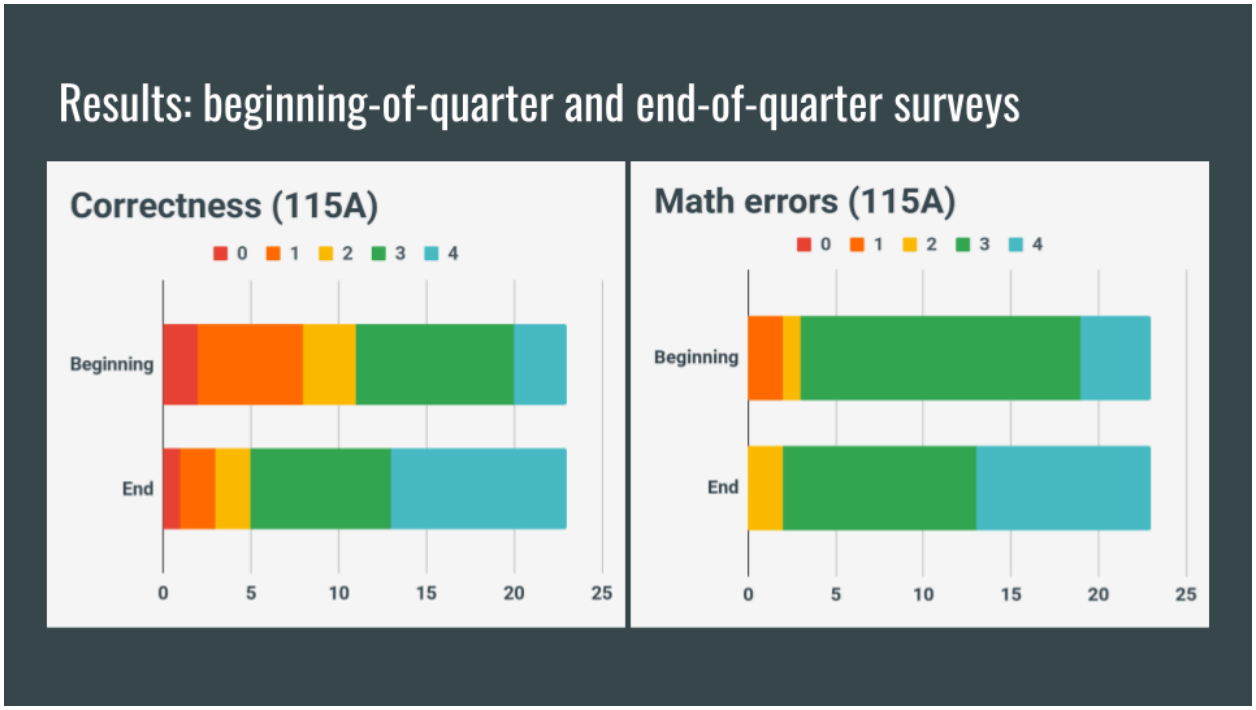


Results: beginning-of-quarter and end-of-quarter surveys

131A (19 students)	BOQ mean	BOQ std. dev.	EOQ mean	EOQ std. dev.	*p*
Understandability	3.47	0.96	3.47	0.61	0.500
Correctness	2.68	1.00	2.79	1.13	0.333
Math errors	3.11	0.81	3.21	0.85	0.333
Grammar errors	2.37	1.21	2.68	1.20	0.195
Typos	2.68	1.20	2.74	1.19	0.442

Results: beginning-of-quarter and end-of-quarter surveys

115A (23 students)	BOQ mean	BOQ std. dev.	EOQ mean	EOQ std. dev.	*p*
Understandability	3.52	0.90	3.61	0.94	0.246
Correctness	2.22	1.24	3.04	1.15	0.001
Math errors	2.96	0.77	3.35	0.65	0.008
Grammar errors	2.65	1.11	2.70	1.02	0.435
Typos	2.57	1.24	2.87	0.97	0.092



What is working well for your learning in this class?

"**Practicing proofs on the board as a team** works really well in understanding different approaches to proofs." [MATH 131A]

"I really appreciate the **participatory elements during lecture**. Having **more practice and immediate feedback** has been really helpful." [MATH 131A]

"I think that the **pedagogical approach** is really interesting. I definitely feel more comfortable regarding the material in a way I can not say I feel about other subjects. The **collaborative atmosphere** is also something that I do not see a lot of in my courses (CS). Specifically, I am beginning to feel confident in tackling a variety of linear algebra related questions even if the contexts differ. I also **feel forced to develop a lot of initiative** in learning the material and rigorous proof-writing." [MATH 115A]

"I really enjoy the **social aspects** of this course. I feel like I am very comfortable speaking with fellow classmates and know many names in this class. I think **having instructor/TA/LA who genuinely are interested in knowing who I am** makes the course (as difficult as it is) warmer as well." [MATH 115A]

"I like the fact that **discussions are used to make progress** in the subjects we cover, and this way we can take our time with each topic **using all 5 days of the week to have an interactive discovery** of the theorems. Interactive discovery is something I value highly, and am glad it is part of the course's design." [MATH 115A]

"I find that the **having us work on proofs within lecture and discussion** is working very well. I also appreciate **having lecture and discussion every day**. It feels as though they are reinforcing each other well." [MATH 115A]

"I think the course is taught in a pretty engaging way … It **makes me try to think for myself** before getting the answer to questions, and this helps with connecting different ideas on my own. Once I got used to the group breakoff style, I also started appreciating this technique of **discovering answers to questions with peers**." [MATH 115A]

Has this course changed your view of writing and communication in mathematics? If so, in what ways? If not, why not?

"I now see mathematical expression as something much more rigorous. The process of mathematical derivation requires careful, logical steps, and I've realized that many concepts can be **traced back to basic definitions and built up gradually** from there. This has deepened my appreciation for precision in mathematical writing, where every step needs to be justified clearly." [MATH 131A]

"Yes, this course has likely changed my view of writing and communication in mathematics by highlighting the importance of clarity and precision in conveying complex ideas. It has also shown me how effective communication is essential for **making mathematical concepts accessible to different audiences**, ensuring that even correct work is understood." [MATH 131A]

"I would say that it has made me dislike the process of communication in mathematics less. I have found for me at least that learning to communicate well in my math has also been helpful in **checking that my own thinking makes sense**. The communication is as much to tell everybody else what I am thinking as it is to tell me what I am thinking." [MATH 115A]

"I think it has shifted my views on what a proof should be and how a math class should operate. I underestimated the importance of **conveying mathematical ideas in a succinct fashion** before this course and **presenting to my peers** changed that notion." [MATH 115A]

"Absolutely! I realize that there are many assumptions that I've often taken for granted in how I communicate things in math/physics in my capacity as a university student — oftentimes assuming that those I talk to/turn my work in to know at least as much as I do and understand these subject matters better. This has helped to further **deconstruct elements of a "as long as I achieve the right answer" mindset**, which often neglects the presentation and straightforwardness of my work." [MATH 115A]

Artifact 3: Student Evaluations of Teaching

Nicholas Hu

Below is a selection of comments from my Student Evaluations of Teaching (emphases are mine).

"Nicholas is amazing! I would even dare to say better than the professor. **He is extremely intelligent, patient, knowledgeable, and adapts to all learning styles, and tries to give examples to make sure all of us understand the material.** He also posts everything on this website that he created himself and makes himself available even beyond the required times for his office hours. **You can truly see he is passionate about his job and desires the best for this student.** If you can promote him or give him a raise, you should!" [COMPTNG 10A, Fall 2021]

"… He is willing to meet individually with any students to address any confusion arising from the vast content of the class. **He also has a fantastic gauge of how the entire class grasps the content which he uses to help Professor Wong.** …" [MATH 32AH, Fall 2022]

"This TA is genuinely exceptional. He not only teaches very well during discussions and makes himself available to everyone during office hours, but is more than willing to go the extra mile outside of OH and discussions. … **I currently have an A in the class, and I can honestly say it would probably be no higher than a C or D without this TA.**" [MATH 32AH, Fall 2022]

"… Nicholas is very good at explaining concepts; **he has a frankly amazing level of patience as he explains things, and never made me feel stupid or less-than at all, even when I wasn't initially understanding the concept. Like Dr. Wong, he does a great job balancing holding us to a high standard in accordance with this being a rigorous and challenging class and being empathetic, helpful, understanding, and non-judgemental while helping us succeed.** Nicholas is doing a fantastic job as a TA and I honestly can't really think of any significant area he needs improvement in, other than just maybe 'zooming in' on a concept when explaining it to help simplify the explanation (he is so smart and knows a ton about math, but sometimes i think his galaxy brain makes these big connections to other concepts that can make it a little harder to follow the problem. Not always, only occasionally)." [MATH 32AH, Fall 2022]

"… He is always great at explaining the hardest concepts of the course. **It is great that he doesn't always give direct answers, but instead leads students towards answers with methods or alternative examples.** This way of teaching is very helpful to learning complex topics" [MATH 32AH, Fall 2022]

"… As one of the most qualified TA's I have encountered, he was always open to questions following discussion and occasionally stayed longer than he was required to to help us find approaches to problems. He kept his explanations organized, concise, and rigorous, and he left helpful comments on our assignments to see us improve. **Looking back, I think I owe much of my understanding of the content to him!**" [MATH 32AH, Fall 2022]

"Nicholas is a very good and diligent TA. He is very patient and always willing to explain something as much as needed until you understand it. **He is also very good at making sure you get everything out of**

the problem/concept that you need to, instead of just helping you understand the problem itself without helping you connect it to the rest of the course as thoroughly as possible. …" [MATH 32BH, Winter 2023]

"… Nicholas is a very good TA and pushes us to be more specific and accurate in our arguments. …" [MATH 32BH, Winter 2023]

"I love this T.A. and his way of teaching. Although he was pretty strict with grading, **it helped me improve my mathematical understanding and how I was able to convey my ideas to my peers**." [MATH 32BH, Winter 2023]

"… Often times [sic] **the discussion offers a better learning experience than the lectures themselves**." [MATH 151A, Fall 2023]

"Nicholas was a great TA for this class. … **His discussion sections were essential to my success in the class.** I went to his office hours a couple times and he was helpful and patient." [MATH 151A, Fall 2023]

"I honestly wish Nicholas just taught the entire course. No offense to the professor. …" [MATH 151A, Fall 2023]

"… **I am glad he is very specific and critical when it comes to writing proofs, as I feel it has improved my proof writing ability tremendously.** I now am more cautious when it comes to the assumptions and logical conclusions I make in order to communicate exactly what I wish to communicate." [MATH 32AH, Fall 2023]

"… He is incredibly clear and organized, and **discussion sections felt like a breath of fresh air in contrast to confusing and meandering lectures**. The TA published lots of useful class materials… and was very helpful during office hours." [MATH 151AH, Winter 2024]

"TA is very clear and precise in regards to explaining mathematical proofs, and I feel that **his criticalness of proofs has greatly improved my proofwriting ability**, teaching me to be cautious and scrutinize my work as closely as possible. …" [MATH 32BH, Winter 2024]

"Nicholas did an incredible job with teaching this class in an enthusiastic and useful way. He was excellent at providing resources and availability outside of class to answer any question that a student might have. **His feedback was invaluable for my development as a teacher.**" [MATH 495, Fall 2024]

"Nicolas [sic] was really thorough with going over questions. Sometimes **he utilised new methods that we weren't exposed to, so having more than one way of solving problems was always useful**. When I had questions about something I was uncomfortable with, we did practice problems until I felt familiarised." [MATH 31A, Fall 2025]

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

(Disclaimer: I tried submitting the template but it cut off text)
Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation
This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.
Name: Ely Jrade (For Nicholas Hu)

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)
Nicholas was my TA in Winter Quarter 2025 for both Math 270B (Computational Linear Algebra) and Math 290M (Qualifying Exam Preparation). I was dual enrolled for the ONLA qualifying exam. I acquainted myself with Nicholas through attending office hours, review sessions, and one-on-one meetings with him during this time.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)
Nicholas' dedication to teaching is unparalleled within the math department and is one of the most inspiring things I have ever witnessed. Math 290M would not exist, were it not for Nicholas' efforts to pitch and promote the idea to the math department, an idea that heretofore went unconsidered. Many others were attempting to pass ONLA along with me and due to Nicholas' efforts, I had a discussion space to engage and practice the challenging material alongside them. This had a tremendous effect. A faculty member on the graduate studies committee later remarked that our cohort of examinees had one of the highest pass rates they had ever seen. Beyond just facilitating a co-operative space for studying efforts, Nicholas proactively challenged students to have a deeper understanding of the material. I was a novice in the subject and when I struggled on quizzes and exams, Nicholas strived to not give away solutions, but lead me to them. He treated me with respect and reassured me that it was possible to demonstrate my knowledge. These efforts showed, as I performed significantly better on the final exam in 270B and subsequently went on to pass my qualifying exam.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)
As many of us were dual enrolled in 270B and 290M, Nicholas went well beyond his suggested TA duties and spent a significant amount of time writing review guides on the more difficult topics cross-listed between the course and the exam. He made these guides publicly available on his website. It is hard to encapsulate the sheer amount of effort that must have gone into producing these materials. They were articulate and deeply illustrative of the recurring patterns connecting different concepts in the subject. They helped demystify and disentangle confusingly similar, yet fundamentally distinct, numerical methods and their underlying motivations.

In addition to crafting these materials, Nicholas also held a review session for the ONLA examinees that covered the more pressing end-of-quarter topics. In roughly two hours, he managed to

assuage nearly all of my anxieties about tackling the material. The session blended traditional lecturing with active learning. For the latter, he curated relevant exam problems, invited students to present solutions, and allowed us to engage in back-and-forth discussion that clarified common conceptual traps. Both of these compassionately crafted additions to the ONLA curriculum demonstrates Nicholas' initiative to aid student learning beyond existing structures.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

While a student of Nicholas', I still needed to pass my preliminary exam along with ONLA. I often felt very overwhelmed. Despite relaying my experience to several other peers and faculty, Nicholas was the first to genuinely engage my perspective and help me work toward a solution. He suggested that we attempt an oral petition of the results of my first qualifying exam, an unprecedented endeavor within the department. After working together to structure an argument and presenting it to the Graduate Vice Chair, the committee eventually approved my petition. Nicholas' care and attention significantly helped me to succeed.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UCLA CEILS
Center for Education Innovation & Learning in the Sciences

February 13, 2026

Dear members of the Distinguished Teaching Awards committee,

This is a letter in strong support of **Nicholas Hu**'s nomination for a Distinguished Teaching Award. Nicholas's dedication to cultivating an inclusive and intellectually engaging learning environment as a teaching assistant and instructor in mathematics is unparalleled at UCLA.

I first met Nicholas when he was a student in my graduate course on Teaching-as-Research, which is part of the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL) program at UCLA. Since then, I have had the pleasure of watching Nicholas implement and disseminate his Teaching-as-Research project at various levels, both locally at his department, as well as across UCLA through the CEILS Journal club. In my experience with Nicholas, I have consistently been impressed by his dedication to constructivist approaches to teaching by facilitating student-led discovery and promoting reflective practice among students in Math.

Teaching students how to write proofs is widely recognized by mathematics faculty as one of the most challenging parts of college-level mathematics teaching. It is a substantial conceptual leap for most college students. For his Teaching-as-Research project, Nicholas chose to address this challenge directly by helping students recognize the importance of communication in mathematics through collaborative proof writing and structured in-class discussions on proofs. He developed original survey items to evaluate the effectiveness of his pedagogical approach towards proof-writing. He implemented this project in Summer 2024 and Spring 2025 in two different math courses, Math 131A-Analysis and Math 115A- Linear Algebra respectively. In his second iteration, he found significant improvements in students' appreciation for the importance of how a mathematical proof is written for its correctness/validity. In addition, his collaborative approach creates a warm, welcoming classroom environment where students feel comfortable engaging with difficult material and skills.

Nicholas's commitment to equity and organizational change goes well beyond his own teaching. Over the last year, Nicholas has been an integral member of the Math SEA Change departmental action team working with CEILS to reduce inequities in introductory mathematics courses at UCLA. As a part of that team, Nicholas highlighted the need for more consistent pedagogical training for the short-term adjunct faculty who teach a substantial portion of these introductory math courses at UCLA. Nicholas's ability to hone in on structural issues instead of adopting a student-deficit lens has been critical to the progress that the departmental team has made so far.

In summary, Nicholas is an outstanding and deeply deserving candidate for the Distinguished Teaching Award. I support his nomination without reservation and would be delighted to elaborate further on the many strengths he brings to his teaching and to the UCLA community.

Sincerely,



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